Study of Social Media Final Research Report

Report for Professors in the Department of Psychology

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PSY 493: Survey Research Methods

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

1 Introduction *3*
2 Methodology *3*
2.1 Sample 3
2.2 Data Collection 4
2.3 Measures 4
3 Results *7*
4 Conclusion *16*
5 References *19*
6 Appendix *19*

1 INTRODUCTION

Social media plays a major role in the lives of college students, influencing how they communicate and build relationships. Research shows that" approximately 95% of college students use social media daily" (Pew Research Center, 2024), making it an important part of their social lives. "Although social media may help teens connect with friends and explore their interests, online interactions can negatively influence their self-esteem and confidence in handling offline social situations in the "real world" (Social Media Victims Law Center, 2025). The goal of this study was to understand the relationship college students have with social media and how it affects their social skills and confidence in real-life social interactions.

To answer these questions, we used a cross-sectional survey design because it allowed us to collect data about social media use and its effects at a single point in time. Specifically, we wanted to answer the following questions:

1. What are college students' attitudes toward social media?
2. At what age did they start using social media, and how has their usage changed before and during college?
3. Do some groups of students start using social media earlier or use it more frequently than others?
4. Is social media usage related to students' social skills and confidence in face-to-face interactions?

The remainder of this report will describe our methodology, data collection and analysis process, results, and survey questions used.

2 METHODOLOGY

2.1 SAMPLE

Data for this study was collected through an online survey distributed through the SONA platform, a system commonly used by psychology departments to manage research participation. The sample consisted of MSU students currently enrolled in a Psychology course that required research participation, as these students regularly check SONA for available studies to complete for course credit. Students who were not part of these courses were ineligible to participate. A convenience sampling method was used, with a target sample size of 150 participants. Recruitment took place entirely online through SONA, where the study was posted with a short description, estimated completion time, and number of credits earned for completion. Students were free to choose whether to participate, which allowed for voluntary and self-selected participation. After the data collection period ended, a total of 211 participants completed the survey.

2.2 Data Collection

The survey was administered online using Qualtrics and distributed to participants through the SONA system at MSU. Students logged into SONA to view a list of available studies, enrolled in this one, and were redirected to the Qualtrics link to complete the survey. Once participants pressed "submit," their responses were recorded. The survey was open for two weeks, providing sufficient time for participation. To encourage participation, students who completed the survey received research participation credits that counted toward their Psychology course requirements.

2.3 Measures

Social Media Attitudes

The Social Media Attitudes construct, which reflects participants' perceptions, feelings, and behaviors related to social media use, was measured with the Social Media Attitude Scale developed by Otrar and Argın (2015). The scale included 23 items. Sample items included:

- "I want my friends to notice me through social media sites."
- "I think social media sites have taken me away from my family."

Items were rated on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (Strongly disagree) to 5 (Strongly agree). Higher scores indicate more positive attitudes and stronger emotional involvement with social media, whereas lower scores reflect less engagement or more negative views. The original scale demonstrated strong internal consistency (Cronbach's $\alpha = .85$; Otrar & Argın, 2015). This measure was selected for its demonstrated validity in assessing social media behavior among young adults.

Social Media Start Age

Social media start age was defined as the age at which participants first engaged with or were exposed to social media. This measure was developed for the current study and included six items. Sample items included:

- "At what age did you start using social media?"
- "At what age did you get your own phone on which you used social media?"

We used the answers to create a continuous variable with lower ages indicating earlier exposure to social media.

Amount of Social Media Usage

A person's amount of social media usage was measured by assessing the frequency and duration of social media use across different ages. This construct was measured using six items created for this study and six items from the Bergen Social Media Addiction Scale (BSMAS; Andreassen et al., 2012). Sample items created for the study included:

- "Currently, on a typical day, how many hours do you spend on social media?"

- "How often do you end up scrolling on social media when you have free time?" (1 = Never to 5 = Almost always)

Sample items from the BSMAS included:

- "You feel an urge to use social media more and more."
- "You spend a lot of time thinking about social media or planning how to use it."

Responses to the BSMAS items were rated on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (Very rarely) to 5 (Very often). Higher scores indicated greater frequency of engagement with social media. The BSMAS has demonstrated high reliability in prior studies (α = .83–.88; Andreassen et al., 2012). This measure was selected because it captures both habitual and compulsive aspects of social media use.

Social Skills

Social skills were measured by evaluating participants perceived communication abilities and sociability. Items were drawn from the Social Skills Inventory (Riggio, 1986) and supplemented with questions developed for this study, resulting in a 12-item measure. Sample items created for the study included:

- "When you are in a social setting, how do you feel?"
- "If you had to pick one, would you call yourself an extrovert or an introvert?"

Sample items from the Social Skills Inventory included:

- "I love to socialize."
- "I usually take the initiative to introduce myself to strangers."

Items from the Social Skills Inventory were rated on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (Not at all like me) to 5 (Exactly like me). Higher scores reflected greater social competence and comfort in interpersonal interactions. Previous research has shown strong internal consistency for the Social Skills Inventory (α > .80; Riggio, 1986). This measure was chosen for its reliability in evaluating interpersonal communication skills and emotional expressiveness among college students.

Confidence in Real-Life Interaction

Confidence in real-life interaction was measured by assessing participants' confidence and comfort in face-to-face social settings. This construct was measured using 22 items, including two questions created for this study and items from the Social Self-Efficacy Scale for Students (SSESS; Fan & Mak, 1998). Sample items created for the study included:

- "How confident do you feel in real-life social situations?" (1 = Not at all confident to 5 = Extremely confident)
- "Do you think you are more or less confident on social media than in real life?" (1 = Much more to 5 = Much less)

Sample items from the SSESS included:

- "I feel confident asking a lecturer a question."
- "It is difficult for me to make new friends."

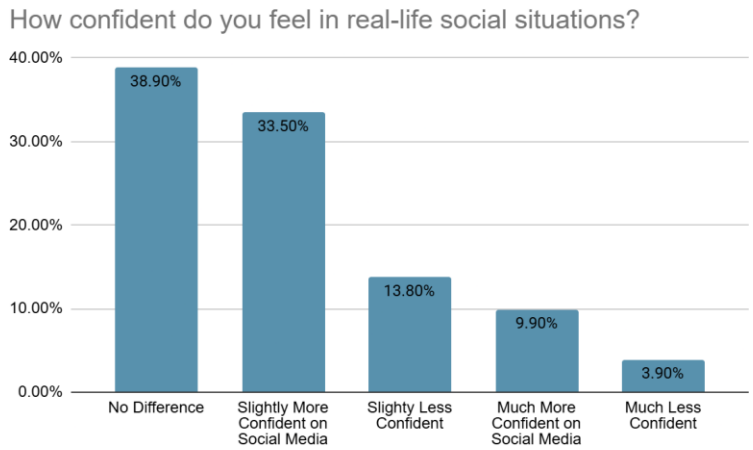
Responses to the SSESS items were rated on a 7-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (Strongly disagree) to 7 (Strongly agree). Higher scores indicated greater social confidence, while reverse-coded items reflected lower confidence or higher social anxiety. The SSESS has demonstrated strong reliability and validity in prior research (Fan & Mak, 1998). This measure was selected for its ability to assess social self-efficacy across different contexts and age groups.

Demographics

The demographics section assessed six participant characteristics: age, gender identity, race/ethnicity, year in school, financial situation, and living arrangement. All items were developed for the current study. Age was measured with an open-ended question asking participants to report their age in years. Gender identity was measured with a categorical item asking participants to select the identity that best described them using the following categories: Agender, Cisgender, Man, Non-binary/Gender Queer/Gender Non-Conforming, Trans/Transgender, Trans Man/Masculine, Trans Woman/Feminine, Two Spirit, Woman, Prefer not to answer, and The gender I most closely align with is not listed (please specify): _____. Race/ethnicity was measured with a categorical item allowing participants to select one or more racial/ethnic categories including: White or Caucasian, Hispanic or Latino, Black or African American, Asian or Pacific Islander, Native American or Alaskan Native, Multiracial or Biracial, prefer not to answer, and A race/ethnicity not listed here (please specify): _____. Year in school was measured with a categorical item asking participants to indicate their current academic year from the following categories: first year, second year, third year, fourth year, fifth year or higher, prefer not to answer. Financial situation was measured with a self-report item asking participants to describe their current financial status and the people who raised them financial situation on the following scale: Living comfortably (more than enough to cover needs and wants), Doing okay (enough to cover needs and some wants), Just getting by (can cover needs but nothing extra), Sometimes struggling to cover basic needs, Often struggling to cover basic needs, and Prefer not to answer. Finally, living arrangement was measured with a categorical item asking whether participants lived on campus, off campus, or preferred not to answer.

3 RESULTS

RQ1. WHAT ARE COLLEGE STUDENTS' ATTITUDES TOWARDS SOCIAL MEDIA?



Participants were asked whether they felt more or less confident in real life compared to on social media. The majority (38.9%) reported no difference in their confidence levels across the two contexts. Meanwhile, 33.5% indicated feeling slightly more confident on social media, while 13.8% stated they felt slightly less confident. A smaller proportion, 9.9%, reported feeling much more confident on social media, and 3.9% expressed feeling much less confident. The majority of students reported no difference in their confidence levels across the two contexts.

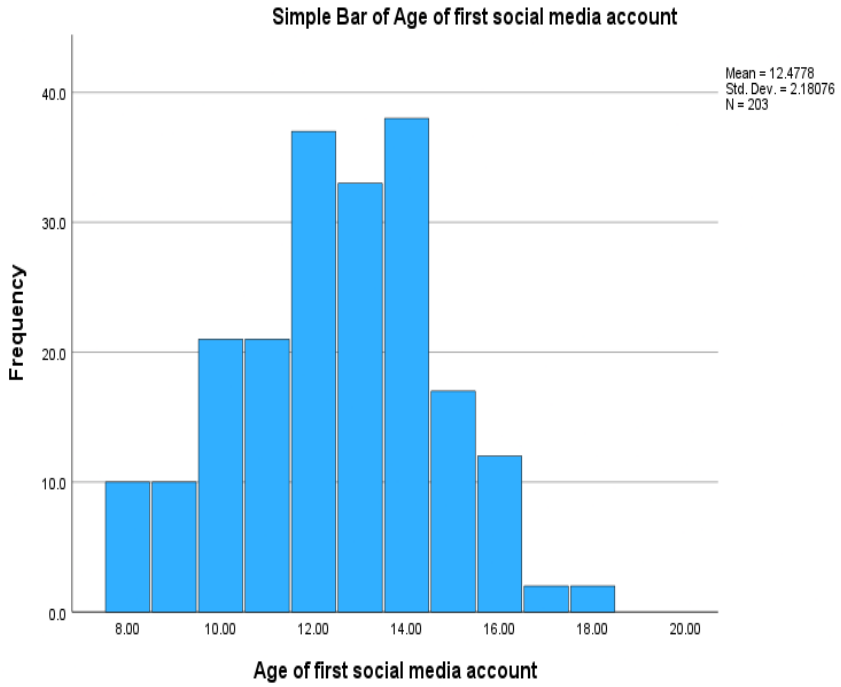
To further explore participants' attitudes, they completed items from the *Social Media Attitude Scale* developed by Otrar and Argın. From this measure, we selected 10 questions (see Table 1) that aligned most closely with the focus of our study. The results of these items are presented in Table 1.

Table [1]: Descriptive Statistics for Social Media Attitudes (RQ1)

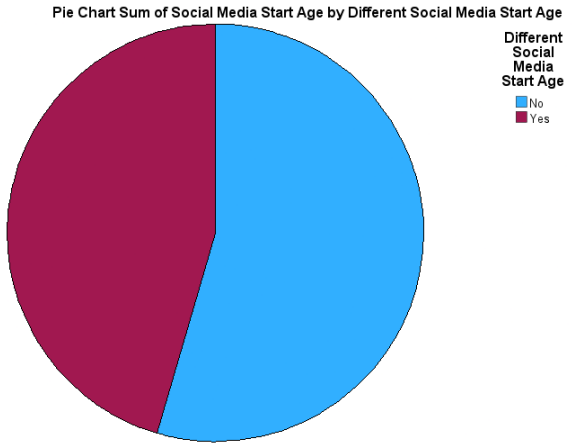
Item	Frequency (%)				
	Strongly Disagree	Somewhat Disagree	Neither agree or disagree	Somewhat agree	Strongly Agree
I want my friends to notice me through social media sites.	18 (8.9%)	38 (18.7%)	63 (31%)	68 (33.5%)	16 (7.9%)

I like to share the posts I see on social media sites with my friends.	**5 (2.5%)**	**2 (1%)**	**11 (5.4%)**	**84 (41.4%)**	**101 (49.8%)**
I like to share articles, videos, music, etc. on social media sites.	10 (4.9%)	42 (20.7%)	28 (13.8%)	83 (40.9%)	40 (19.7%)
I think that I have survived my loneliness through social media sites.	43 (21.2%)	36 (17.7%)	52 (25.6%)	59 (29.1%)	13 (6.4%)
I can't spend enough time with my family because of social media sites.	**125 (61.6%)**	**56 (27.6%)**	**13 (6.4%)**	**7 (3.4%)**	**2 (1%)**
I think that I can reach people with common interests and goals through social media sites.	6 (3%)	15 (7.4%)	44 (21.7%)	107 (52.7%)	31 (15.3%)
I can't spend enough time on other social activities because of social media sites.	84 (41.4%)	71 (35%)	27 (13.3%)	18 (8.9%)	3 (1.5%)
I am happy to spend time on social media sites.	4 (2%)	17 (8.4%)	55 (27.1%)	115 (56.7%)	12 (5.9%)
I think I will have more friends thanks to social media sites.	28 (13.8%)	62 (30.5%)	46 (22.7%)	54 (26.6%)	13 (6.4%)

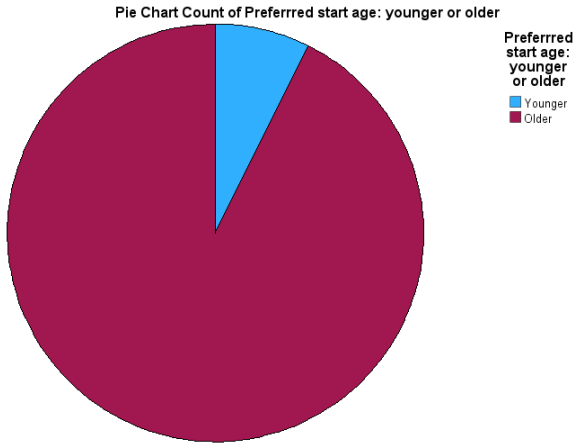
RQ2A. AT WHAT AGE DID STUDENTS START USING SOCIAL MEDIA?



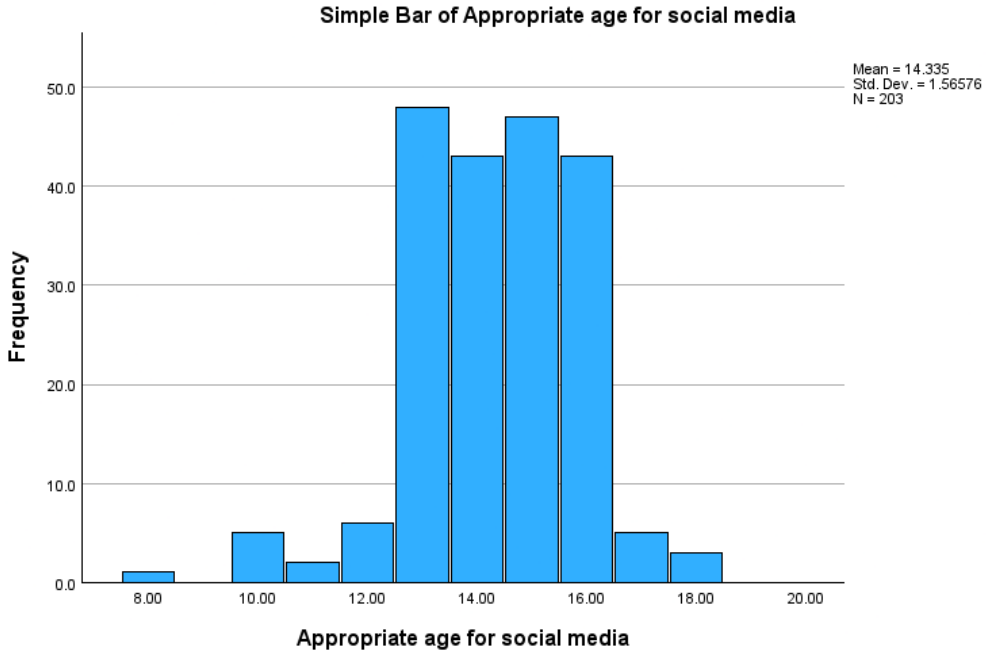
Students were asked at what age they first began using social media. The majority reported starting at age 13 (17.2%). Across 203 responses, ages ranged from 7 to 19, with a mean of 12.36 years (SD = 2.21).



When asked whether they wished they had started using social media at a different age, responses were fairly evenly split: 108 students (53.2%) said no, while 95 (46.8%) said yes.

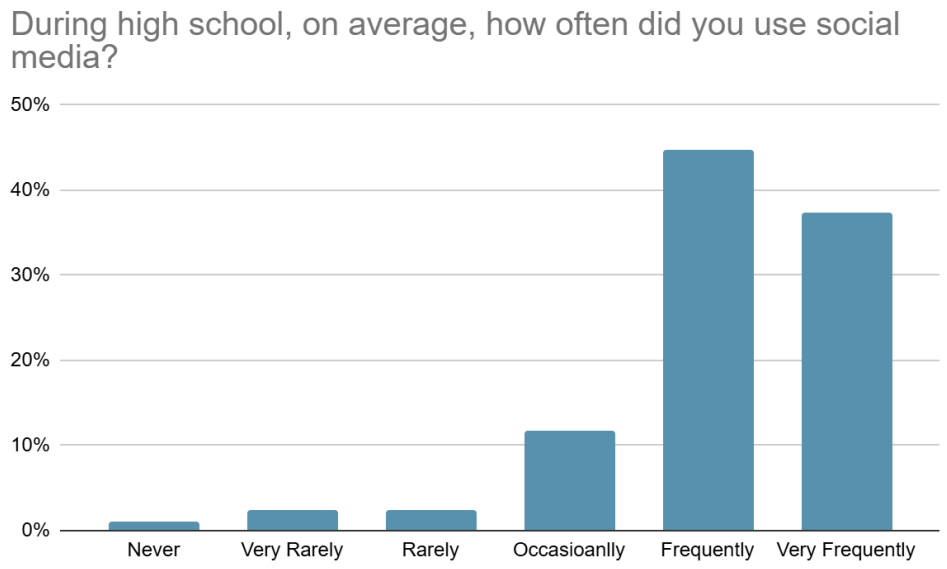


Of those who wished they had started at a different age, the vast majority (92.6%) indicated they would have preferred to start later, while only 7.4% wished they had started earlier.



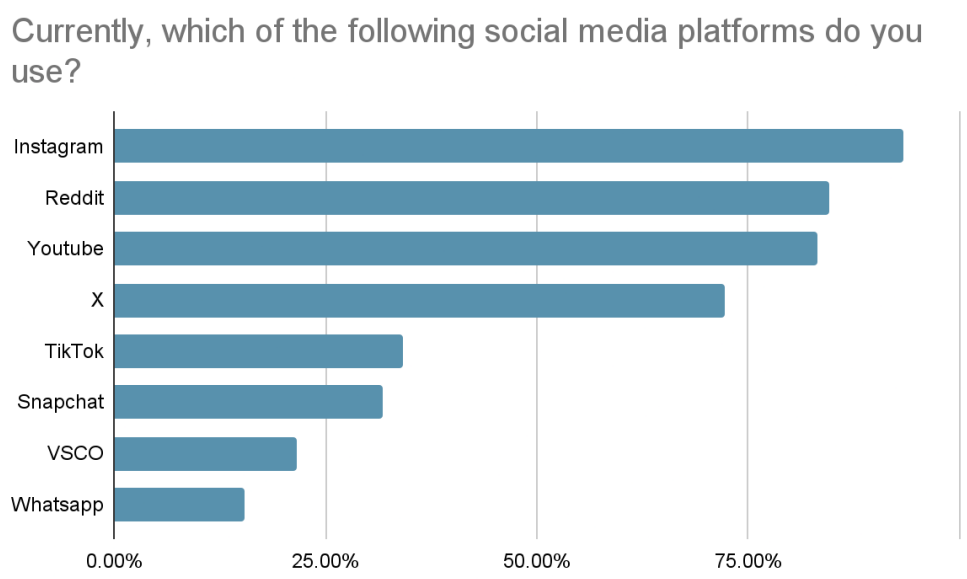
Students also reported the age at which they obtained their first social media account, which ranged from 8 to 18 years (M = 12.48, SD = 2.18). The most common age for receiving a first account was 14. Similarly, students shared the age at which they received their first phone, ranging from 7 to 19 years (M = 12.18, SD = 2.09), with the majority reporting age 13. When asked what they believed to be the most appropriate age for beginning social media use, responses ranged from 8 to 18 years (M = 14.34, SD = 1.57), with the most common response being 13.

RQ2B. HOW MUCH DID THEY USE SOCIAL MEDIA BEFORE STARTING COLLEGE?



Students were also asked about their social media usage during high school. On average, participants reported using social media 6.41 days per week (SD= 1.44).
Students were asked how frequent they used social media in high school. Majority answered frequently (44.8%).

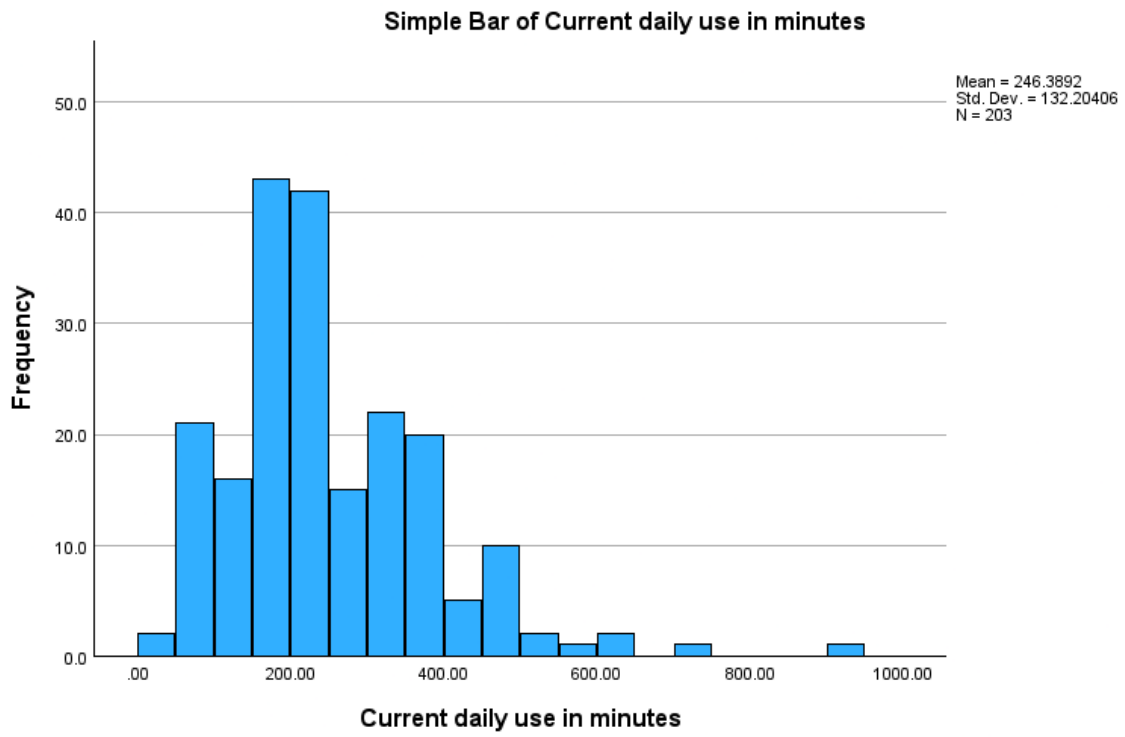
RQ2C. HOW MUCH SOCIAL MEDIA DO THEY USE DURING COLLEGE?



When asked which platforms they used most frequently in college, Instagram was the most common (93.3%), followed by TikTok (84.6%), Snapchat (83.2%), YouTube (72.15%), Facebook (34.1%), VSCO (31.7%), X (21.6%), Reddit (16.3%), and WhatsApp (15.4%). (pie chart)

In terms of scrolling behavior, 2 students (1%) reported scrolling rarely, 31 (15.3%) sometimes, 100 (49.3%) often, and 70 (34.5%) almost always. To assess potential problematic use, the Bergen Social Media Addiction Scale (BSMAS) was administered. Scores ranged from 1 to 5, with a mean of 2.48 (SD = .78), indicating that most responses fell between “rarely” and “sometimes.”

Students also reported the amount of time they spent on social media daily. After converting responses into minutes, the average usage was 246.39 minutes per day (SD = 132.20).



RQ3A. DO SOME GROUPS OF STUDENTS START USING SOCIAL MEDIA AT A YOUNGER AGES THAN OTHERS?

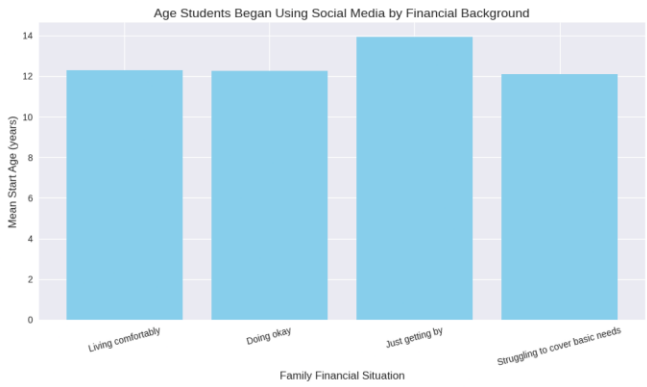


Table [4]: ANOVAs for [Social media start age/Family financial] (RQ3)

Variable	Living Comfortably		Doing Okay		Just Getting By		Sometimes or Often Struggling To cover basic needs		F (df, df)	95% Confidence Interval
	M	*SD*	*M*	*SD*	*M*	*SD*	*M*	*SD*		
Social media Start Age	*12.30*	*2.24*	*12.25*	*2.09*	*12.93*	*2.59*	12.25	1.83	.395 (3,197)	(.0,.028)

* p < .05; ** p < .01; ***p < .001

A one-way ANOVA was conducted to examine whether the age at which students first began using social media differed across groups based on family financial situation. Participants were classified into four groups: living comfortably (n = 99), doing okay (n = 80), just getting by (n = 15), and sometimes or often struggling to cover basic needs (n = 9). Assumption checks indicated no outliers, as assessed by boxplot. Data were normally distributed within each group, as assessed by histograms, skewness and kurtosis values, and the Shapiro–Wilk test (p > .05). However, the assumption of homogeneity of variances was violated, as indicated by Levene's test (p = .040). Descriptive statistics showed that the mean start age was 12.29 years (SD = 2.24) for students living comfortably, 12.25 years (SD = 2.09) for those doing okay, 13.93 years (SD = 4.62) for those just getting by, and 12.11 years (SD = 1.76) for those struggling to cover basic needs. Although the mean start age varied slightly across groups, the differences were not statistically significant, F(3, 27.16) = 2.23, p = .595.

RQ3B. DO SOME GROUPS OF STUDENTS USE MORE SOCIAL MEDIA THAN OTHERS?

Table [2]: T-tests for [Race Ethnicity/Start age, Current daily use in minutes] (RQ3)

	Race Ethnicity		
	White or Caucasian	People of color	
	M (*SD*)	*M* (*SD*)	*t* (*df*)
Start Age	12.14 (1.99)	12.84 (2.53)	-1.87 (85.9)
Current daily use in minutes	242.84 (127.10)	258.84 (146.50)	-.786 (196)

A Welch's *t*-test was conducted to examine whether current daily minutes of social media use differed by race. The sample included 141 participants who identified as White and 57 participants who identified as people of color. Assumption checks indicated two outliers, as assessed by inspection of a boxplot. Social media use was normally distributed for both groups, as assessed by histograms, skewness and kurtosis values, and the Shapiro–Wilk test ($p < .05$). The assumption of homogeneity of variances was not violated, as indicated by Levene's test ($p = .744$). Descriptive statistics showed that participants of color reported slightly higher daily social media use (M = 258.84 minutes, SD = 146.50) compared to White participants (M = 242.43 minutes, SD = 127.11). However, this difference was not statistically significant, $t(196) = -0.79$, $p = .433$, with a mean difference of -16.41 minutes (95% CI [-57.56, 24.74]).

People of color had a later mean start age of social media and a higher current daily use in minutes.

Table [3]: T-tests for [gender/ Current daily use in minutes] (RQ3)

	Gender		
	women	men	
	M (*SD*)	*M* (*SD*)	*t* (*df*)
Current daily use in minutes	242.62 (133.83)	233.50 (93.2)	.357 (188)

An independent-samples Welch *t*-test was conducted to examine whether current daily minutes of social media use differed by gender. The sample included 160 women and 30 men. Assumption checks indicated three outliers, as assessed by inspection of a boxplot. Social media use was normally distributed for both groups, as assessed by histograms, skewness and kurtosis values, and the Shapiro–Wilk test ($p < .05$). The assumption of homogeneity of variances was violated, as indicated by Levene's test ($p = .056$), and therefore Welch's *t*-test was used. Descriptive statistics showed that women reported slightly higher daily social media use (M = 242.63 minutes, SD = 133.83) compared to men (M = 233.50 minutes, SD = 93.28). However, this difference was not statistically significant, $t(188) = 0.36$, $p = .721$, with a mean difference of 9.13 minutes (95% CI [-41.28, 59.53]).

RQ4. Is social media usage related to social skills?

Is social media usage related to confidence in real life interaction?

Table [5]: Correlations for Social Skills, Confidence in real life interactions, and Social Media Usage (RQ4)

Variable	1	2	3	4	5
1. Social Skills	1.0				
2. Social Skills/ Introvert-Extrovert	.630**	1.0			
3. Social self-Efficacy	-.323**	-.353**	1.0		
4. Confidence in real life interactions	.592**	.567**	-.350**	1.0	
5. Social Media Usage	.036	.098	-.071	.073	1.0

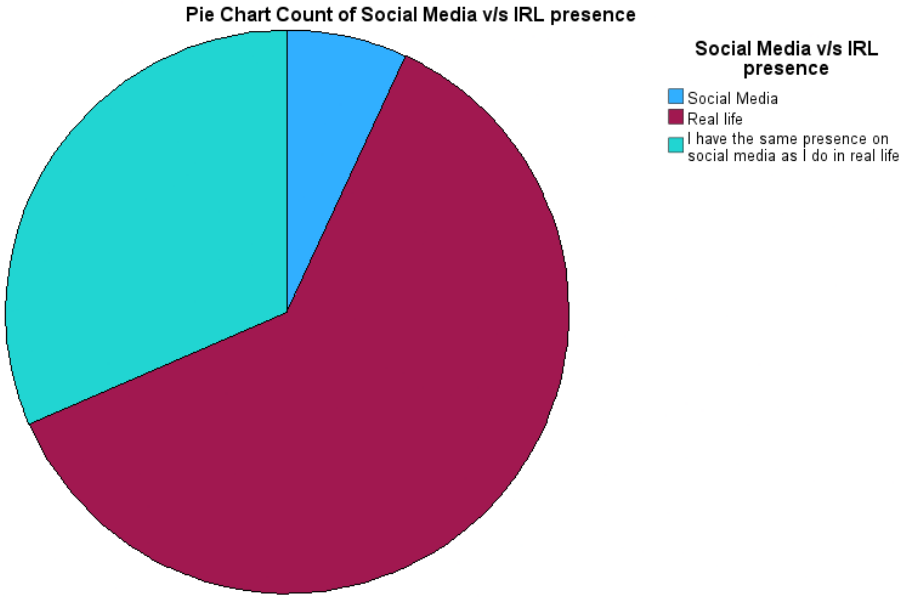
* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; ***$p < .001$

Spearman's rho correlations were calculated to assess the associations among social skills, introversion–extroversion, social self-efficacy, confidence in real-life interactions, and social media usage. Social skills were strongly and positively associated with introversion–extroversion ($\rho = .630$, $p < .01$), indicating that participants who reported stronger social skills also tended to identify as more extroverted. Social skills were also strongly and positively related to confidence in real-life interactions ($\rho = .592$, $p < .01$). In contrast, social skills showed a moderate

negative relationship with social self-efficacy ($\rho = -.323$, $p < .01$), suggesting that higher self-reported social skills were linked to lower perceived social self-efficacy.

Introversion–extroversion demonstrated similar patterns, showing a strong positive association with confidence in real-life interactions ($\rho = .567$, $p < .01$) and a moderate negative association with social self-efficacy ($\rho = -.353$, $p < .01$). Confidence in real-life interactions was also moderately and negatively correlated with social self-efficacy ($\rho = -.350$, $p < .01$).

Social media usage did not demonstrate any significant correlations with the psychological variables. All coefficients were small and nonsignificant (ρs ranging from –.071 to .098), indicating that the amount of social media use was not meaningfully related to participants' social skills, personality orientation, self-efficacy, or confidence in offline interactions.



Finally, students were asked whether they felt they had more of a presence on social media or in real life. Fourteen students (6.7%) reported having more of a presence on social media, 125 (60.1%) reported having more of a presence in real life, and 64 (30.8%) reported having an equal presence in both contexts.

4 Conclusion

Summary and Purpose of the Study

The purpose of this study was to examine college students' social media attitudes, usage patterns, and the relationship between social media behaviors and social functioning. The study explored when students first began using social media (RQ2), how their confidence and attitudes relate to social media (RQ1), whether usage differs across demographic groups (RQ3), and

whether social media use is associated with social skills, introversion–extroversion, social efficacy, or real-life confidence (RQ4).

KEY TAKEAWAYS AND INTERPRETATION

RQ1: Confidence and Attitudes Toward Social Media

Key takeaway: Most students (38.9%) reported that their confidence was the same on social media and in real life. Others felt slightly more confident (33.5%) or slightly less confident (13.8%). Responses to the Social Media Attitude items showed that students generally enjoy sharing content, connecting with others, and spending time on social media, but most did not feel that social media negatively affected family time or social activity.

What this means: These findings suggest that, overall, students view social media as a neutral-to-positive extension of their social lives rather than a space where they feel dramatically more or less confident. Their attitudes indicate that social media serves primarily as a tool for entertainment, connection, and self-expression rather than compensation for loneliness or lack of real-life interaction.

RQ2: Age of First Use, Early Attitudes, and Current Usage Patterns

Key takeaway: Students typically began using social media around age 12–13, received their first account at a similar age, and got their first phone slightly earlier. Nearly half wished they had started at a different age—and almost all of those wished they had started later. Students now use social media heavily, averaging 6.41 days per week and just over 4 hours per day.

What this means: Students seem to retrospectively feel that early social media exposure may have been premature. Despite this, their current usage is extremely high, suggesting that social media has become deeply embedded in daily life. Their preferred platforms (Instagram, TikTok, Snapchat) align with national trends for college-aged adults.

RQ3: Demographic Differences in Social Media Use and Start Age

Key takeaway:

- **Family financial background:** No significant differences in social media start age across financial groups.
- **Race:** Students of color began using social media slightly later than White students—this difference was statistically significant but small (about 0.7 years).
- **Gender:** Women used social media slightly more than men, but the difference was not statistically significant.
- **Race and daily use:** No significant differences in daily usage minutes.

What this means: Social media use patterns are highly consistent across demographic groups, suggesting that access and behaviors are fairly universal. The small racial difference in start age may reflect differences in access to early technology rather than substantial behavioral differences.

RQ4: Social Media Use and Social Functioning

Key takeaway: Social media usage (in days per week) showed no meaningful relationship with social skills, introversion–extroversion, social self-efficacy, or real-life confidence. All correlations were weak and non-significant.

What this means: These findings suggest that how often students use social media is not strongly connected to their social abilities or personality traits. Contrary to some concerns, heavier social media use did not predict lower real-life confidence or poorer social skills. It appears that students' social functioning is shaped more by other factors outside of social media behavior.

Conclusion and Future Directions

Overall, this study suggests that college students view social media as a normal, integrated part of daily social life—neither a major source of confidence nor a significant detriment. Usage patterns are heavy but remarkably similar across demographic groups. Importantly, social media use does not appear to influence social skills, confidence, or social self-efficacy.

Future Research

Future studies could:

- Examine how specific types of social media activities (e.g., passive scrolling vs. active posting) relate to mental health and social functioning.
- Explore longitudinal patterns, including how early starting youth feel about social media as they transition into adulthood.
- Investigate how platform-specific features (such as algorithms, filters, or messaging styles) influence well-being or social confidence.

Practical Implications / Interventions

Colleges might consider:

- Offering digital wellness workshops that help students reflect on early adoption and develop healthier long-term habits.
- Creating programs that highlight balanced media use, since many students retrospectively wish they had started later.
- Providing resources for first-year students to build real-life social confidence, acknowledging that social media neither improves nor harms these skills by itself.

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4 APPENDIX

Attach the questionnaire (Exported from Qualtrics in a clean format) as an appendix.

Q1 **IMPORTANT CONSENT INFORMATION - Please Read Carefully before Continuing**

You are being asked to participate in a research study. Researchers are required to provide a consent form to inform you about the research study, to convey that participation is voluntary, to explain risks

and benefits of participation, including why you might or might not want to participate, and to empower you to make an informed decision.

The purpose of this research study is to investigate psychology students' social media attitudes and behavior. Participation in this study involves completing an online survey, which should take about 30 minutes. **The survey is completely anonymous; your name or any other identifying information will not be collected**.

Your participation in this research study is completely voluntary. You have the right to say no to participating, and you can stop participating at any time after you start the survey without consequences.

Please note that most questions on this survey are required to be answered. The exception is demographic questions (i.e., basic questions about you), for which a "prefer not to answer" option is available. We require the completion of questions to ensure we have the data necessary to answer our research questions.

You will not benefit personally from being in this study, and there are no foreseeable risks to participating.

The data will be stored for up to three years in a Psychology Department server. Because you will not be asked to provide any personally identifiable information, the data files will have no identifying information; no one will be able to connect your name with the data.

If you have concerns or questions about this study, such as scientific issues, how to do any part of it, or to report an injury, contact the primary investigator: Adrienne Adams, Ph.D. 338 Psychology Building Michigan State University E. Lansing, MI 48824-1116 adamsadr@msu.edu 517-353-4568 If you have questions or concerns about your role and rights as a research participant, would like to obtain information or offer input, or would like to register a complaint about this study, you may contact, anonymously if you wish, the Michigan State University's Human Research Protection Program at 517-

355-2180, Fax 517-432-4503, or e-mail irb@msu.edu or regular mail at 4000 Collins Rd, Suite 136, Lansing, MI 48910.Click to write the question text

Q2 Are you willing to participate in this research study?

Yes (1)

No (2)

Q3 The first set of questions is about social situations. Please take your time when answering. There are no “right” or “wrong” answers. You should answer in the way that is right for you, being as truthful as possible. As a reminder, this survey is **anonymous**. No one will be able to connect your answers to you.

Q4 When you are in a social setting with a large group of people, how do you typically feel?

Energized and excited (1)

Happy and comfortable (2)

Neutral — it doesn’t affect me much (3)

A bit tired or overwhelmed (4)

Drained and want to leave (5)

Q5 Below is a list of statements about social situations. Please rate each statement according to how much like you it sounds on a scale from 0 = Not at all like me to 4 = Exactly like me.

	0 - Not at all like me (0)	1 - Somewhat not like me (1)	2 - Neither like nor not like me (2)	3 - Somewhat like me (3)	4 - Exactly like me (4)

I love to socialize. (1)

I can be comfortable with all types of people — young and old, rich and poor. (2)

I always mingle at parties. (3)

I can be strongly affected by someone smiling or frowning at me. (4)

I usually take the initiative to introduce myself to strangers. (5)

I'm generally concerned about the impression I'm making on others. (6)

I can easily adjust to being in just about any social situation. (7)

When I'm with a group of friends, I am often the spokesperson for the group. (8)

At parties, I can immediately tell when someone is interested in me. (9)	
I can easily tell a person's character by watching them interact with others. (10)	

Q6 If you had to pick one, would you call yourself an extrovert or an introvert?

Introvert (Someone who feels best when they spend time alone or in quiet places.) (1)

Extrovert (Someone who feels best when they're around other people and busy with activities.) (2)

Q7 How confident do you feel in real-life social situations?

0 - Not at all confident (0)

1 - A little confident (1)

2 - Moderately confident (2)

3 - Quite confident (3)

4 - Extremely confident (4)

Q8 Below is a list of statements about social situations. Please indicate how much you disagree or agree with each statement on a scale from 1 = Strongly disagree to 7 = Strongly agree.

	1- Strongly disagree (1)	2 - Disagree (2)	3 - Somewhat disagree (3)	4 - Neither agree nor disagree (4)	5 - Somewhat agree (5)	6 - Agree (6)	7 - Strongly agree (7)

I do not handle myself well in social gatherings. (1)	
It is difficult for me to make new friends. (2)	
I have difficulties making new friends at college. (3)	
I find it difficult to hold a conversation with most people (4)	
I have difficulties participating in class discussions (5)	
I am usually quiet and passive in social situations (6)	
I have difficulties getting a date when I want one. (7)	

Q9 Below is a list of statements about social situations. Please indicate how much you disagree or agree with each statement on a scale from 1 = Strongly disagree to 7 = Strongly agree.

	1 - Strongly disagree (1)	2 - Disagree (2)	3 - Somewhat disagree (3)	4 - Neither agree nor disagree (4)	5 - Somewhat agree (5)	6 - Agree (6)	7 - Strongly agree (7)

I have difficulties talking to university staff. (1)	
It is difficult for me to express a different opinion. (2)	
I feel confident asking a lecturer a question (3)	
I feel confident talking to my lecturers. (4)	
I feel confident in asking questions in class. (5)	
I am confident of my language skills (6)	
I feel comfortable requesting information. (7)	

Q10 Below is a list of statements about social situations. Please indicate how much you disagree or agree with each statement on a scale from 1 = Strongly disagree to 7 = Strongly agree.

	1 - Strongly disagree (1)	2 - Disagree (2)	3 - Somewhat disagree (3)	4 - Neither agree nor disagree (4)	5 - Somewhat agree (5)	6 - Agree (6)	7 - Strongly agree (7)

I have common topics of conversation with people in my life. (1)	
I have common interests with people in my life. (2)	
I enjoy activities that most people in my life enjoy. (3)	
When I'm trying to become friends with someone who seems uninterested at first, I don't give up easily. (4)	
If I see someone I would like to meet, I go to that person instead of waiting for them to come to me (5)	
I feel confident in joining student organizations. (6)	

Q11 This next set of questions is about social media. Again, this survey is **anonymous.** No one will be able to connect your answers to you.

Q12 Have you ever used social media?

No (0)

Yes (1)

Q13 How much more or less confident are you on social media than in real life?

Much more confident on social media than in real life (5)

Slightly more confident on social media than in real life (4)

No difference - the same level of confidence on social media and in real life (3)

Slightly less confident on social media than in real life (2)

Much less confident on social media than in real life (1)

Q14 Below is a list of statements about social media. Please indicate how much you disagree or agree with each statement on a scale from 1 = Strongly disagree to 5 = Strongly agree.

	1 - Strongly disagree (1)	2 - Somewhat disagree (2)	3 - Neither agree nor disagree (3)	4 - Somewhat agree (4)	5 - Strongly agree (5)

I want my friends to notice me through social media sites. (1)	
I feel that I have gained a new personality through social media sites. (2)	
I don't think social media sites are driving me away from my friends. (3)	
I like to share the posts I see on social media sites with my friends. (4)	
I like to comment on content on social media sites. (5)	
I like to share articles, videos, music, etc. on social media sites. (6)	
I think social media sites have taken me away from my family. (7)	

Q59 Below is a list of statements about social media. Please indicate how much you disagree or agree with each statement on a scale from 1 = Strongly disagree to 5 = Strongly agree.

	1 - Strongly disagree (1)	2 - Somewhat disagree (2)	3 - Neither agree nor disagree (3)	4 - Somewhat agree (4)	5 - Strongly agree (5)

I want my friends to notice me through social media sites. (1)	
I feel that I have gained a new personality through social media sites. (2)	
I don't think social media sites are driving me away from my friends. (3)	
I like to share the posts I see on social media sites with my friends. (4)	
I like to comment on content on social media sites. (5)	
I like to share articles, videos, music, etc. on social media sites. (6)	
I think social media sites have taken me away from my family. (7)	

Q15 Below is a list of statements about social media. Please indicate how much you disagree or agree with each statement on a scale from 1 = Strongly disagree to 5 = Strongly agree.

	1 - Strongly disagree (1)	2 - Somewhat disagree (2)	3 - Neither agree nor disagree (3)	4 - Somewhat agree (4)	5 - Strongly agree (5)

I think that I have survived my loneliness through social media sites. (1)	
I like to follow my teachers on social media sites. (2)	
I like it when my teachers follow what I write. (3)	
I can't spend enough time with my family because of social media sites. (4)	
I like my shares being liked by my friends. (5)	
I think that I can reach people with common interests and goals through social media sites. (6)	
I can't spend enough time on other social activities because of social media sites. (7)	
I am happy to spend time on social media sites. (8)	

Q16 Below is a list of statements about social media. Please indicate how much you disagree or agree with each statement on a scale from 1 = Strongly disagree to 5 = Strongly agree.

	1 - Strongly disagree (1)	2 - Somewhat disagree (2)	3 - Neither agree nor disagree (3)	4 - Somewhat agree (4)	5 - Strongly agree (5)

I can express my feelings more easily through social media sites to my special interest friend. (1)

I like to be aware of the events organized through social media sites. (2)

I think I will have more friends thanks to social media sites. (3)

The fact that my teachers follow me on social media sites makes me feel valuable. (4)

I think that I need to be respected thanks to social media sites. (5)

I am happy that my friends comment on my posts. (6)

I cannot pay enough attention to my classes because of social media sites. (7)

I can't spend enough time with my friends because of social media sites. (8)

Q17 At what age did you start using social media? If you don't remember exactly, provide your best guess.

Q18 Do you wish you started using social media at a different age?

Yes (1)

No (0)

Display this question: If Do you wish you started using social media at a different age? = Yes

Q19 Do you wish you were younger or older?

Younger (1)

Older (2)

Q20 At what age did you have your first social media account? If you don't remember exactly, provide your best estimate.

Q21 At what age did you get your own phone on which you used social media? If you don't remember exactly, provide your best estimate.

Q22 What do you think is an appropriate age to get exposed to social media?

Q23 During high school, on average, how often did you use social media? If you don't remember exactly, provide your best estimate.

0 - Never (6)

1 - Very rarely (5)

2 - Rarely (4)

3 - Occasionally (3)

4 - Frequently (2)

5 - Very frequently (1)

Q24 During high school, how many days in a typical week did you use social media? If you don't remember exactly, provide your best estimate.

Q25 Currently, which of the following social media platforms do you use?

Instagram (1)

Youtube (2)

Reddit (3)

X (4)

Tiktok (5)

Facebook (6)

Snapchat (7)

VSCO (8)

Whatsapp (9)

Carry Forward Selected Choices from "Currently, which of the following social media platforms do you use?"

Q26 Click and drag to rank order the apps you use based on how often you use them, with 1 being the most often, 2 being the second most often, and so on.

_____ Instagram (1)
_____ Youtube (2)
_____ Reddit (3)
_____ X (4)
_____ Tiktok (5)
_____ Facebook (6)
_____ Snapchat (7)
_____ VSCO (8)
_____ Whatsapp (9)

Q27 Currently, how often do you end up scrolling on social media when you have free time?

Never (1)

Rarely (2)

Sometimes (3)

Often (4)

Almost always (5)

Q28 Currently, how many days in a typical week do you use social media?

Q29 On the days that you use social media, how much time do you approximately spend on it in a day?

Use the spaces below to record hours and minutes. For example, if you spend 1 hour and 15 minutes, you would enter "1" in the "Hours" box and "15" in the "Minutes" box. If you spend 45 minutes on social media, you would enter "0" in the "Hours" box and "45 in "Minutes" box.

Hours (0 to 24) (1) _____

Minutes (0 to 59) (2) _____

Q30 Do you feel like you have more presence on social media or in real life?

Social Media (1)

Real Life (2)

I have the same presence on social media as I do in real life (3)

Q31 Here are six statements to consider. For each, answer: (1) very rarely, (2) rarely, (3) sometimes, (4) often, or (5) very often.

	1 - Very Rarely (1)	2 - Rarely (2)	3 - Sometimes (3)	4 - Often (4)	5 - Very Often (5)

You spend a lot of time thinking about social media or planning how to use it. (1)	
You feel an urge to use social media more and more. (2)	
You use social media in order to forget about personal problems. (3)	
You have tried to cut down on the use of social media without success. (4)	
You become restless or troubled if you are prohibited from using social media. (5)	
You use social media so much that it has had a negative impact on your job/studies. (6)	

Q32 This is the last set of questions. We'd like to collect some basic demographic information from you. We will not be able to use this information to identify you. But, if there is anything you'd prefer not to share, please respond "prefer not to answer."

Q33 How old are you?

Q34 What year are you in college?

First year (1)

Second year (2)

Third year (3)

Fourth year (4)

Fifth year or higher (5)

Prefer not to answer (6)

Q35 Do you live on campus or off campus?

On campus (1)

Off campus (2)

Prefer not to answer (3)

Q36 How would you describe the current household financial situation of the people who raised you?

Living comfortably (more than enough to cover needs and wants) (1)

Doing okay (enough to cover needs and some wants) (2)

Just getting by (can cover needs but nothing extra) (3)

Sometimes struggling to cover basic needs (4)

Often struggling to cover basic needs (5)

Prefer not to answer (6)

Q37 How would you describe your current household financial situation?

Living comfortably (more than enough to cover needs and wants) (1)

Doing okay (enough to cover needs and some wants) (2)

Just getting by (can cover needs but nothing extra) (3)

Sometimes struggling to cover basic needs (4)

Often struggling to cover basic needs (5)

Prefer not to answer (6)

Q38 What is your race or ethnicity?

White or Caucasian (1)

Hispanic or Latino (2)

Black or African American (3)

Asian or Pacific Islander (4)

Native American or Alaskan Native (5)

Multiracial or Biracial (6)

A race/ethnicity not listed her (please specify): _____ (7)
_____

Prefer not to answer (8)

Q39 How do you describe your gender identity (select all that apply):

Agender (1)

Cisgender (2)

Man (3)

Non-binary/Gender Queer/Gender Non-Conforming (4)

Trans/Transgender (5)

Trans Man/Masculine (6)

Trans Woman/Feminine (7)

Two Spirit (8)

Woman (9)

Prefer not to answer (10)

The gender I most closely align with is not listed (please specify): _____ (11)
_____

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